foraging parties would swoop down, looking for loot and hostages. They would leave behind a trail of arson, pillage and terror in their wake.

One of the major reasons why the British had hesitated in getting involved in Ahom politics was the probable quantum of troops that would be required to control such a vast expanse of land. However, Captain Welsh's six companies of sixty men each had shown that a small body of troops, equipped with the best available weapons, could defeat any enemy, regardless of their larger numbers. It was also obvious that Indian soldiers, when exposed to sordid political machinations, as was the case with the Ahom kingdom, were not too effective as a cohesive fighting force. In addition, the directors of the East India Company were always looking to curtail costs. Maintaining armies was an expensive business and in keeping with Company policy, after the Burmese War, troop strength in Assam was greatly reduced.

The need to protect the fast expanding tea gardens and imported labour now became a major problem. Regular army units had shrivelled to just four regular battalions (forbears of the 6th and 8th Gorkhas). Accordingly, it was decided to raise a levy that would operate directly under the civil government and would be distinct from both the regular army and the armed police. The levy was to be placed on a better military footing than the police so that they could be used instead of regular troops along the tribal border. The initial troops for the levy were to be drawn from the armed Bengal Civil Police and it was to be officered by police officials. Accordingly, the first unit of the new organization, the Cachar Levy, was raised in 1834-35 by Mr Grange, the civilian officer in charge at Nowgong.

Shortly after the raising of the Cachar Levy, the British undertook the first of a series of excursions into Naga territory. While the stated aim of the first expedition into Naga territory in 1839 was to dominate the Naga tribes and restrain them from their frequent raiding, another important factor was that the British had learnt that the king of Manipur was planning to include the Naga Hills in his territory. As the British consolidated their hold on the region, the levy began to emerge as the strong arm of the government. By 1862, the force had been reorganized and renamed 'Frontier Police' and fresh battalions were raised, their name dependent on their place of origin.

By 1878, the British decided to further consolidate their hold on the region. A Forward Policy was adopted and new areas were annexed. The role of the Frontier Police changed from a mainly defensive posture to a